The Master Meal Planning Guide

Your Science-Backed Blueprint for Sustainable Fat Loss, Metabolic Health, and Lifelong Habits



BY J.C. STORGANAU

Contents

Your roadmap from confusion to a plan that fits real life.

Why Everything You've Tried Has Failed . . . 4

This guide is for you if... . . . 4

Three principles that run through every page . . . 5

How to use this guide . . . 5

Chapter 1: The Real Science of Fat Loss . . . 6

Your body isn't broken . . . 6

The energy balance truth . . . 6

Why crash diets betray you . . . 7

5 metabolism myths, debunked . . . 8

Chapter 2: Finding Your Number . . . 9

The calculator problem . . . 9

The Mifflin-St Jeor formula . . . 9

The 14-Day Discovery Protocol . . . 10

Reading your body's signals . . . 11

The adjustment rule: metabolic feedback . . . 11

Common tracking mistakes . . . 12

Chapter 3: Working With Your Metabolism, Not Against It . . . 13

Carbs: friend or foe? . . . 13

The simple carb-cycling framework . . . 14

The timing advantage . . . 15

Food quality matters more than you think . . . 15

Meal examples and templates . . . 15

Chapter 4: Building Habits That Actually Stick . . . 17

Willpower is overrated . . . 17

Design your environment, design your success . . . 18

Never miss twice: the Two-Day Rule . . . 18

Habit stacking . . . 19

Social-situation strategies . . . 19

Chapter 5: Eating for Energy, Focus and Modern Life . . . 20

Your brain on food . . . 20

The productivity connection . . . 21
The GLP-1 era . . . 21
Fiber: the forgotten superpower . . . 22
How to add fiber without digestive distress . . . 23
2026 trends worth knowing . . . 23

Chapter 6: Your Implementation Toolkit . . . 24
The weekly planning system . . . 24
Batch-cooking guide . . . 25
Protein supplements decoded . . . 26
When things go off track . . . 27
Plateau-busting checklist . . . 27

Appendix A: Sample Meal Plans . . . 29
Vegetarian and vegan alternatives . . . 32

Appendix B: Quick Reference Guides . . . 34
Daily and weekly checklists . . . 34
Grocery staples . . . 35
Portion-size visual guide . . . 35
Emergency meal options . . . 35
Hydration . . . 36
Sleep optimisation checklist . . . 36

Appendix C: FAQ: Your Questions Answered . . . 37

Appendix D: Resources and Next Steps . . . 39
Recommended apps . . . 39
Kitchen equipment essentials . . . 39
Further reading . . . 40
When to get professional help . . . 40
Your 30-day action plan . . . 40
Selected sources . . . 40

SHORT ON TIME? START HERE

10 minutes? Read the Chapter 2 summary and start the 14-Day Discovery Protocol.

Overwhelmed? Read “Never miss twice” and the “Never Zero” rule in Chapter 4.

Need food fast? Jump to Appendix A (meal plans) and Appendix B (emergency meals).

START HERE



Why Everything You've Tried Has Failed

...and why this time is different.

INSIDE

- Why "calories in, calories out" is only half the story
- The three principles behind this guide
- Who this guide is (and isn't) for
- A 4-week roadmap and what you'll need

Let's be honest for a second. You've probably downloaded guides like this before. Maybe you've tried keto, intermittent fasting, calorie-counting apps, meal-delivery services, or the juice cleanse your coworker wouldn't stop talking about.

And yet, here you are. Not because you lack willpower, and not because you're lazy. Most nutrition advice simply treats you like a robot: a simple input-output machine where "calories in, calories out" is supposed to explain everything.

> *Your body is not a calculator. It's an adaptive system that responds to stress, sleep, hormones, emotions and the quality of what you eat, not just the quantity.*

> A FAIR CLARIFICATION
>
> Calories still matter. A sustained energy deficit is what drives fat loss. What this guide adds is the missing half: how big a deficit *you* can actually sustain depends on hunger, energy, sleep, stress and habits, and all of those are things you can manage.

This guide is for you if...

- You're tired of starting over every Monday
- You've lost weight before but couldn't keep it off
- You feel confused by conflicting nutrition advice
- You want a system that works with real life, not a vacation version of it
- You're ready to understand *why* things work, not just follow rules

Three principles that run through every page

1. Understanding beats restriction

When you know *why* something works, you're far more likely to stick with it.

2. Flexibility beats perfection

Life happens. The goal isn't a flawless plan, it's a resilient one.

3. Systems beat willpower

You shouldn't have to white-knuckle every meal. Design your routines and environment instead.

This isn't about transformation in 30 days. It's about building a relationship with food that serves you for the next 30 years.

BEFORE YOU START

This guide is general education for healthy adults, not medical advice. Talk with your doctor or a registered dietitian first if you are pregnant or breastfeeding, under 18, take medication, or have diabetes, kidney disease, thyroid or heart conditions.

If you have a history of disordered eating, or if tracking food tends to trigger anxiety or obsession, skip the calorie-tracking steps and work with a qualified professional instead. If you use a GLP-1 medication, your prescriber's plan comes first (see Chapter 5).

How to use this guide

Read it once, then live it. Don't try to implement everything at once; the smart approach is a slow build:

Week	Read	Do
1	Chapters 1–2	Start the 14-Day Discovery Protocol. Just observe; don't change anything yet.
2	Chapters 3–4	Adjust your calories using your own data. Add **one** habit from Chapter 4. Try one higher-carb and one lower-carb day (optional).
3	Chapters 5–6	Add the energy-focus-satisfaction score. Build your first weekly meal plan with the templates.
4+	Appendices	Use the sample plans, quick guides and FAQ as your playbook, not a one-time read.

What you'll need

- A food-tracking app (Cronometer, MyFitnessPal or Lose It!)
- A digital food scale (about $15–20)
- Measuring cups and spoons
- A notebook or notes app
- 15–20 minutes on Sunday for weekly planning

Success looks like

- Losing about 0.5–1% of body weight per week (roughly 0.5–2 lb)
- Steady energy through the day
- Feeling satisfied after meals, not stuffed or hungry
- Not thinking about food constantly
- Enjoying social events without "derailing"

This is not about

- Perfection
- Cutting out whole food groups forever
- Hours of meal prep every week
- Never eating out or celebrating

CHAPTER 1

1

The Real Science of Fat Loss

Understand the system you're working with before you try to change it.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- Your body isn't broken
- The energy balance truth
- Why crash diets betray you
- 5 metabolism myths, debunked

THE BIG IDEA

Fat loss needs an energy deficit, but your body defends against deficits that are too large. The winning strategy is a moderate deficit, high protein, strength training and more everyday movement.

Your body isn't broken

If you've ever felt like your metabolism is working against you, you're not wrong. But it isn't broken: it's doing exactly what evolution designed it to do, which is to protect you from starvation.

When you slash calories too aggressively, your body doesn't applaud your discipline. It adapts. Hunger hormones rise, energy output drops, and you feel like you're dragging through molasses. That isn't a character flaw. It's biology.

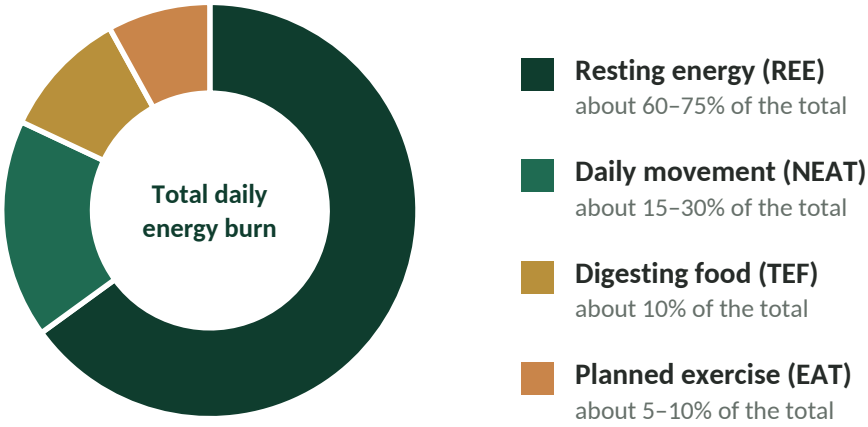
THE CAR-ENGINE ANALOGY

Think of your metabolism like a car engine. Your resting metabolism (REE) is the idle speed: the energy burned just to keep running. When you restrict calories severely, your body turns the idle down to conserve fuel. This is **metabolic adaptation**.

After weight loss, energy expenditure typically falls by somewhat more than the lost body mass alone would predict, often by a few hundred calories a day and more after very aggressive diets. That is why "just eat less" gets harder over time, and why a moderate deficit works better than a severe one.

The energy balance truth

Fat loss comes down to energy balance, just not in the oversimplified way you've heard. Your total daily energy expenditure (TDEE) is made of four parts:



Illustrative split. Real proportions vary by person; ranges are shown on the right.

Component	Share	What it is	Your leverage
Resting energy (REE)	60–75 %	Calories burned just existing: brain, heart, lungs, organs. Largely set by lean body mass.	Protect muscle with protein and strength training.
Thermic effect of food (TEF)	~10%	Energy used to digest and process food. Protein 20–30%, carbs 5–10%, fat 0–3%.	Build meals around protein and whole foods.
Daily movement (NEAT)	15–30 %	All movement outside the gym: walking, fidgeting, standing, chores. Differs by up to ~2,000 kcal/day between people.	Steps, standing, active habits. The most underrated lever.
Planned exercise (EAT)	5–10%	Your actual workouts. Often overestimated, and the smallest slice for most people.	Train for muscle and health, not as a calorie-burning tool.

The takeaway: planned exercise is the smallest piece, which is why “just exercise more” is weak advice. The real leverage points are protecting your muscle (and so your resting metabolism), eating enough protein, and raising everyday movement in ways you can sustain.

Why crash diets betray you

Standard calorie calculators can be off by several hundred calories in either direction, setting you up for frustration before you even start. And the PREDICT research showed that even identical twins eating the same meals can have noticeably different blood-sugar and fat-metabolism responses, thanks to differences in gut bacteria and lifestyle.

Translation: **there is no universal “right” number**, and chasing one is exhausting. Instead, treat your calorie target as a starting hypothesis, not a final verdict. You’ll test it, gather data and adjust based on what your body actually does. Chapter 2 shows you how.

5 metabolism myths, debunked

Myth	The truth
"Eating late at night makes you gain weight."	Total daily calories matter more than the clock. Late eating can, however, disrupt sleep and lead to poorer food choices, which affects weight indirectly.
"You need six small meals to boost your metabolism."	Meal frequency has minimal effect on metabolic rate. Eat in whatever pattern helps *you* control hunger.
"Cardio is the best way to lose fat."	Strength training helps preserve muscle during weight loss, which protects your metabolic rate. The best approach combines both.
"Some people are just born with slow metabolisms."	Genetics play a role, but most differences are explained by muscle mass, daily movement (NEAT) and under-reported food intake.
"You must be in a deficit every single day."	Weekly averages matter more than daily perfection. Some days you'll eat more, some less. Follow the trend, not the day.

CHAPTER 2

2

Finding Your Number

(Without losing your mind.) Use a formula as a rough draft, then let your own data write the final version.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- The calculator problem
- The 14-Day Discovery Protocol
- Reading your body's signals
- Common tracking mistakes

THE BIG IDEA

Your starting number comes from a formula; your *real* number comes from two weeks of honest tracking. Adjust using your trend, how you feel, and your energy, not a single day on the scale.

The calculator problem

You've probably plugged your stats into an online calculator that told you something like "you need 1,847 calories a day." The uncomfortable truth: that number is probably off. Formulas like Mifflin-St Jeor were built on specific study populations and can't account for your unique metabolism, stress, sleep or how your body adapts over time.

That doesn't make them useless. Think of them as a rough draft: a sensible starting point for your personal experiment.

The Mifflin-St Jeor formula

Among the most validated estimates for the general population. Use kilograms (lb ÷ 2.2) and centimetres (inches × 2.54).

	Resting energy (REE) in kcal/day
Men	(10 × weight in kg) + (6.25 × height in cm) − (5 × age in years) + 5
Women	(10 × weight in kg) + (6.25 × height in cm) − (5 × age in years) − 161

Then multiply by an activity factor to estimate your total daily energy expenditure (TDEE):

Activity level	Description	Multiply by
Sedentary	Little or no exercise, desk job	× 1.2
Light	Exercise 1–3 days/week	× 1.375
Moderate	Exercise 3–5 days/week	× 1.55
Active	Exercise 6–7 days/week	× 1.725
Very active	Physical job plus training	× 1.9

WORKED EXAMPLE

Sarah, 35, 150 lb (68 kg), 55″ (165 cm), moderately active.

REE = (10 × 68) + (6.25 × 165) − (5 × 35) − 161 = 680 + 1,031 − 175 − 161 = **1,375 kcal**

TDEE = 1,375 × 1.55 = **2,131 kcal/day**. For fat loss: 2,131 − 500 = **1,631 kcal/day**.

Remember, this is an estimate: Sarah's true needs could easily be 200–400 calories higher or lower.

The 14-Day Discovery Protocol

Instead of obsessing over the "perfect" number up front, collect your own data.

Week 1: Baseline (days 1–7)

Log **everything** you eat and drink in an app

Don't change anything yet. Just observe

Weigh yourself every morning (after the bathroom, before eating)

Rate your energy 1–10 at 3 pm

Day 1: take front, side and back photos

Week 2: Gentle adjustment (days 8–14)

Work out your average daily intake from Week 1

For fat loss, subtract **300–500 kcal** from that average

Prioritise protein: **0.7–1 g per lb** of body weight

Track your weekly average weight and your energy

What to track: all food and drink (yes, that sip of your partner's soda), cooking oils and condiments, workouts and daily steps, sleep hours and quality, and hunger before and after meals.

WORKED EXAMPLE

If Sarah averages 2,400 kcal in Week 1 and her weight stays flat, her real TDEE is about 2,400, not the 2,131 the calculator predicted. Her fat-loss target: 2,400 − 400 = **2,000 kcal/day**.

Why this works: you're building a plan on *your* actual behaviour, not a theoretical ideal, which dramatically improves your odds of sticking to it.

A FLOOR, NOT A GOAL

As a general safety floor, avoid eating below roughly 1,200 kcal/day (women) or 1,500 kcal/day (men) unless a doctor or dietitian is supervising you. Smaller deficits you can sustain beat bigger ones you can't.

Reading your body's signals

The scale is one data point. These matter just as much:

Area	If you notice...	Try...
Hunger	Ravenous two hours after eating	More protein or fiber at that meal
	Never hungry	You may be under-eating; check intake
	Craving specific foods	Check for emotional triggers, sleep debt, or nutrient gaps
Energy	Crashing by 3 pm	Rebalance carb timing or total intake
	Can't sleep	Eating too late, or deficit too large
	Morning fatigue	Review sleep quality and evening nutrition
Performance	Workouts feel harder	May need more carbs or calories
	Recovery taking longer	More protein and sleep
	Constantly sore	Check overall energy availability
Mood	Irritable and snappy	Your body is signalling stress; add calories
	Food obsession	May be too restrictive; add volume and fiber
	Social withdrawal	Reassess whether your approach is sustainable

The adjustment rule: metabolic feedback

Use your weekly average weight (not single days) to decide what to do next. This feedback loop is worth more than any formula.

If...	Then...
No downward trend after 2–3 weeks of accurate tracking	Cut about 100–200 kcal **or** add about 2,000 steps a day. Pick one, not both.
Losing faster than ~1% of body weight per week **and** feeling poor	Add 100–200 kcal back. Faster is not better.
Losing 0.5–1% of body weight per week with good energy	**Stay the course.** It's working.

Common tracking mistakes

Mistake	The fix
Eyeballing portions	Use a food scale for the first two weeks. A “handful” of almonds can be 100 or 300 calories.
Forgetting oils and condiments	Track everything. One tablespoon of olive oil is about 120 kcal.
Not tracking drinks	Cream in coffee, juice, soda and alcohol all count. Even “healthy” smoothies can top 500 kcal.
Inconsistent weigh-ins	Weigh at the same time each morning. Daily weight can swing 1–3 lb on water alone, so look at the weekly average.
Giving up after 3 days	Commit to the full 14 days. Three days is noise; two weeks is data.
Obsessing over daily numbers	Focus on weekly averages. Some days you’ll be over, some under. That’s normal.

CHAPTER 3

3

Working With Your Metabolism, Not Against It

Carbs, timing and food quality: the levers that make a deficit feel easier.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- Carbs: friend or foe?
- The simple carb-cycling framework
- The timing advantage
- Food quality matters
- Meal templates

THE BIG IDEA

Carbs aren't the enemy. Matching them to your activity, eating mostly whole foods and keeping protein high makes a deficit more comfortable, but total calories and protein still do most of the work.

Carbs: friend or foe?

Let's end the drama: carbohydrates are not the enemy. But *when* and *how much* you eat them can matter more than you've been told.

On heavy training days your muscles are primed to use glucose for fuel and recovery. On rest days you need less. **Carb cycling** simply matches your carbohydrate intake to your activity: more where you train, less where you don't.

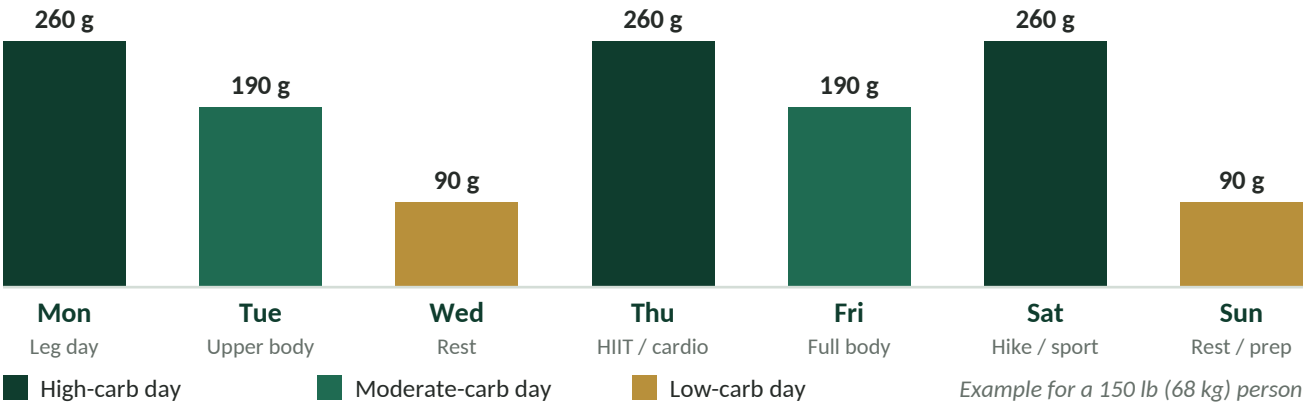
HONEST EVIDENCE CHECK

Research suggests that total calories, protein and consistency drive most fat-loss results, and carb cycling is not magic. Its real value is practical: better fuel for hard sessions and more food flexibility. If it adds stress or complexity, skip it and keep carbs steady.

The simple carb-cycling framework

Day type	Carbs per lb	For a 150 lb person	Emphasis
High (hard training days)	1.5–2 g	225–300 g	Carbs around the workout (before and after). Oats, rice, potatoes, fruit. Protein moderate-high, fat lower.
Moderate (lighter training)	1–1.5 g	150–225 g	Balanced plate: whole grains, fruit, vegetables.
Low (rest days)	0.5–0.75 g	75–110 g	Vegetables, healthy fats and high protein. Leafy greens, avocado, nuts, olive oil.

A typical week (grams shown for a 150 lb person):



Example for a 150 lb (68 kg) person

Day	Activity	Carb target	Example foods
Mon	Leg day (hard)	High (1.5–2 g/lb)	Oats, rice, potatoes
Tue	Upper body (moderate)	Moderate (1–1.5 g/lb)	Quinoa, fruit, vegetables
Wed	Rest	Low (0.5–0.75 g/lb)	Eggs, salad, fish, vegetables
Thu	HIIT / cardio	High (1.5–2 g/lb)	Oats, rice, sweet potato
Fri	Full body (moderate)	Moderate (1–1.5 g/lb)	Whole grains, fruit
Sat	Active (hiking / sport)	High (1.5–2 g/lb)	Varied carbs
Sun	Rest / meal prep	Low (0.5–0.75 g/lb)	Protein, vegetables, healthy fats

TRY THIS

The 5/2 model. Five weekdays at moderate carbs (1–1.5 g/lb). Two weekend days adjusted to your plans: higher carbs for an active weekend (hiking, sports), lower for a rest weekend. It's the easiest way to start.

A caution: staying very low-carb for long stretches can limit high-intensity training and is hard for many people to sustain. Cycling keeps flexibility.

The timing advantage

Chrono-nutrition is the idea that *when* you eat matters alongside *what* you eat. Insulin sensitivity tends to be higher earlier in the day, and several studies link eating more of your calories earlier with better blood-sugar control and appetite. The evidence is still emerging and mixed, so use it as a guideline, not a rule. The best schedule is the one you can keep.

Morning

Eat within 1–2 hours of waking, or whenever real hunger shows up

Include protein plus some carbs

Example: Greek yogurt, berries, granola

Midday

Make lunch or an early dinner your biggest meal if that suits you

A good place for most of your carbs

Example: grain bowl with protein and vegetables

Evening

Finish dinner 2–3 hours before bed

Keep it lighter in carbs, higher in protein and fat

Example: grilled fish, roasted vegetables, olive oil

Why it helps: it lines up with your circadian rhythm, supports better sleep, and can reduce late-night cravings.

Food quality matters more than you think

You can hit your macros perfectly and still struggle with hunger, energy crashes and stalled progress. Why? Because **100 calories of chicken breast do not act in your body like 100 calories of potato chips**.

Ultra-processed foods are engineered to bypass your natural fullness signals. In a tightly controlled trial, people given ultra-processed meals ate roughly 500 more calories a day than when given unprocessed meals matched for presented calories, sugar, fat and fiber. Whole foods with the same calories keep you fuller for longer.

> KEY IDEA
>
> **The 80/20 rule:** aim for about 80% whole, minimally processed foods and leave 20% for flexibility. It's not about perfection; it's about a pattern that serves you.

400 calories of...	Fullness	Energy impact	Nutrient density
Grilled chicken, quinoa, broccoli	High (8/10)	Steady for 4–5 hours	High
Fast-food burger and fries	Low (4/10)	Often a crash within ~2 hours	Low
Protein shake, apple, almonds	High (7/10)	Steady for 3–4 hours	Moderate-high
Granola bar, soda, chips	Low (3/10)	Often a crash within ~90 minutes	Very low

Ratings are illustrative guides, not lab measurements; individual responses vary.

Meal examples and templates

These two sample days (for a 150 lb person) show how the same protein target looks on a high-carb training day and a low-carb rest day. Values are estimates (±10%).

High-carb training day

Meal	What's on the plate	kcal	Protein	Carbs
Breakfast	3/4 cup dry oats cooked in water, 1 scoop protein powder, 1 banana, 1 tbsp honey	510	33 g	88 g
Pre-workout	3 rice cakes, 1 tbsp jam	160	2 g	35 g
Post-workout	6 oz chicken breast, 1.5 cups cooked white rice, 2 cups mixed vegetables, 1 tsp olive oil	720	63 g	86 g
Dinner	5 oz salmon, 1 medium sweet potato, 2 cups steamed broccoli, lemon and herbs	520	40 g	49 g
Total	about 37 g fat	**1,910**	**138 g**	**258 g**

Roughly 1,910 kcal, 258 g carbs (about 1.7 g/lb), 138 g protein, 37 g fat.

Low-carb rest day

Meal	What's on the plate	kcal	Protein	Carbs
Breakfast	3 scrambled eggs, 1/2 avocado, 2 cups wilted spinach, 1 tsp butter	380	22 g	9 g
Lunch	6 oz grilled chicken, large salad, 1 tbsp olive-oil dressing, 1/4 cup chickpeas	510	58 g	19 g
Snack	1 cup plain nonfat Greek yogurt, 1/2 cup berries, 1 small apple	250	24 g	39 g
Dinner	6 oz steak, 2 cups roasted asparagus, side salad with 1 tbsp vinaigrette, 1 oz cheese	620	64 g	16 g
Total	about 86 g fat	**1,760**	**168 g**	**83 g**

Roughly 1,760 kcal, 83 g carbs (about 0.6 g/lb), 168 g protein, 86 g fat.

CHAPTER 4

4

Building Habits That Actually Stick

The plan only works if you can still follow it on a stressful Thursday.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- Willpower is overrated
- Design your environment
- Never miss twice: the Two-Day Rule
- Habit stacking
- Social-situation strategies
- The “Never Zero” rule

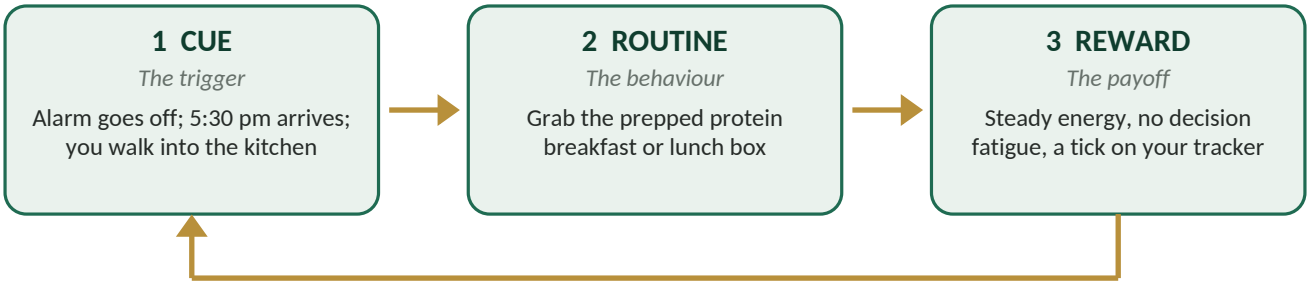
THE BIG IDEA

Willpower is limited. Habits and environment are not. Make the healthy choice the easy, obvious choice, and when you slip, reset at the very next meal.

Willpower is overrated

Here’s the real reason most diets fail: it isn’t that you’re weak. Most meal plans ask you to spend willpower on every single food decision, and willpower runs low when you’re tired, stressed or hungry.

People with strong **self-efficacy** (the belief that they *can* carry out a behaviour) tend to do better than those relying on white-knuckle discipline. The difference is systems. Every habit follows a simple loop, and the trick is to work with it:



Repeat it and the loop strengthens. Design your environment to make the cue obvious and the routine easy.

Design your environment, design your success

Your willpower doesn't stand a chance against a poorly designed environment. Make the right choice the easy choice.

Kitchen audit checklist

Refrigerator

- ☐ Eye level: pre-cut vegetables, boiled eggs, Greek yogurt
- ☐ Door: water, sparkling water (not juice or soda)
- ☐ Crispers: washed, ready-to-eat produce
- ☐ Back: treats in opaque containers

Pantry and counter

- ☐ Front shelves: nuts, seeds, whole-grain crackers, canned beans
- ☐ Back shelves: chips, cookies, processed snacks
- ☐ Counter: fruit bowl and water pitcher, not a cookie jar

Portion control

- ☐ Smaller plates can nudge portions down (evidence is modest)
- ☐ Pre-portion snacks into small containers
- ☐ Serve from the stove, not family-style at the table

Smart shopping strategy

- **Never shop hungry.** Most of what you eat all week is decided at the store.
- Shop the perimeter first (produce, meat, dairy), then pick up staples.
- Make your list in the order of the store sections.
- Set a timer: rushed decisions are poor decisions.
- Don't buy trigger foods "for the family." You'll eat them.

Never miss twice: the Two-Day Rule

Here's the habit-building secret: **don't try to be perfect forever.** When "eating well for the rest of my life" feels overwhelming, your brain rebels. But two days? That's manageable. Two days becomes four, four becomes a week, and soon you're not thinking about it anymore.

Part	How it works
Start small	When motivation is low, tell yourself: "I'll just do this today and tomorrow." After two days, ask: "Can I do two more?"
Never miss twice	One slip is an accident. Two in a row is the start of a new habit. Never let more than two consecutive days go off-plan.
Reset immediately	Return to your plan at the very next meal. Don't wait for Monday.

Habit stacking

Attach new habits to things you already do, using the formula **"After I [existing habit], I will [new habit]."**

When	After I...	I will...
Morning	pour my coffee	log yesterday's food
	brush my teeth	take my morning weight
	sit at my desk	plan today's meals
Evening	finish dinner	prep tomorrow's lunch
	brush my teeth at night	set out breakfast items
	get into bed	rate today's energy and focus (1–10)

Social-situation strategies

Restaurants

Check the menu online and decide beforehand

Ask for dressings and sauces on the side

Build your order: protein + vegetable + a portioned starch

Alcohol: 1–2 drinks, alternating with water

Family gatherings

Bring a dish you know you can enjoy

Fill half your plate with vegetables first

Pressure line: "It looks amazing, I'm saving room for later"

Take healthy leftovers home

Work events

Eat a protein-rich snack 1–2 hours before

Stand away from the food table

Sparkling water with lime looks like a cocktail

Have a natural exit after 60–90 minutes

Travel and vacation

Pack snacks: protein bars, nuts, jerky

Hotel breakfast: eggs, fruit, yogurt

Room service: grilled protein and vegetables

Enjoy local food, then get back on track at the next meal

THE "NEVER ZERO" RULE

On your worst day, do *something*. Can't meal-prep? Buy a rotisserie chicken and a bagged salad. Too tired to cook? A protein shake and a piece of fruit. Ate off-plan all day? Drink water and get a full night's sleep.

Never let a bad day become a bad week. One meal doesn't define your progress.

CHAPTER 5

5

Eating for Energy, Focus and Modern Life

What you eat shapes how you think, feel and perform, not just how you look.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- Your brain on food
- The productivity connection
- The GLP-1 era
- Fiber: the forgotten superpower
- 2026 trends worth knowing

> **THE BIG IDEA**
> Good nutrition is also a performance tool. Track how meals make you *feel*, protect muscle (especially on GLP-1 medication), and make fiber a daily priority.

Your brain on food

Here's something most nutrition guides skip: **what you eat affects how you think.** Diet influences inflammation, gut-brain signalling and cognitive performance. Observational studies link Mediterranean-style eating (rich in fiber, healthy fats and plants) with better memory, focus and mood stability, while diets heavy in ultra-processed foods are associated with brain fog and fatigue. These are associations, not guarantees, but the direction is consistent.

Nutrient	Found in	Why it matters	Aim for
Omega-3 (EPA/DHA)	Salmon, sardines, mackerel; walnuts and flax (ALA)	Supports brain cell structure; helps manage inflammation	2 servings of fatty fish a week, or ask a clinician about a supplement
B vitamins	Leafy greens, eggs, legumes, whole grains	Energy metabolism, neurotransmitter synthesis	A B-rich food at most meals
Polyphenols	Berries, dark chocolate, green tea, colourful vegetables	Antioxidant and anti-inflammatory compounds	A "colour" at every meal

The productivity connection

Some biohacking influencers make bold claims about nutrition and output. Treat those with scepticism: you don't need extremes, and no study can tell you how *your* body responds. What you can do is run your own small experiment.

> **THE ENERGY-FOCUS-SATISFACTION SCORE**
>
> Each day, rate on a 1–10 scale: **morning energy** (9–11 am), **afternoon focus** (2–4 pm) and **evening satisfaction** (8–10 pm). Track for two weeks and look for patterns.
>
> • Do heavy-carb lunches crash your afternoon? • Does skipping breakfast make you irritable? • Does late dinner affect your sleep?

Day	Breakfast	Lunch	Dinner	Energy	Focus	Notes
Mon	Oats + protein	Chicken, rice	Salmon, veg	8/10	6/10	Post-lunch dip
Tue	Eggs, avocado	Large salad	Steak, veg	9/10	8/10	Steady energy
Wed	Skipped	Pasta, bread	Pizza	5/10	4/10	Brain fog all day

Example insight: skipping breakfast and a big refined-carb lunch lined up with poor focus; a protein-rich breakfast plus a balanced lunch lined up with better afternoons.

The GLP-1 era

If you're reading this in 2026, you probably know someone using semaglutide (Ozempic, Wegovy), tirzepatide (Mounjaro, Zepbound) or another GLP-1 medication. These drugs can be transformative for weight loss, but they come with a catch: by dramatically reducing appetite and calorie intake, they raise the risk of losing muscle along with fat. That makes **protein, resistance training and regular meals** especially important.

> **MEDICATION COMES FIRST**
>
> If you take a GLP-1 medication, follow your prescriber's and dietitian's guidance first. The numbers below are general starting points, not individual medical advice.

Priority	General guidance
Protein	Commonly recommended: about 0.55–0.8 g per lb (1.2–1.8 g/kg) of *goal* body weight, spread across 3–4 small meals of roughly 25–40 g each.
Don't skip meals	Low appetite doesn't mean low needs. Small, protein-first meals protect muscle and energy.
Strength training	Non-negotiable. Two to four sessions a week to preserve muscle.
Hydration and fiber	Sip water through the day; build up to 25–30 g of fiber to help with constipation.
Nausea	Eat slowly, stop at comfortable fullness, and go easy on very greasy or rich foods.
Micronutrients	With much lower food intake, ask your clinician whether a multivitamin makes sense.

Sample GLP-1 day (about 1,400 kcal)

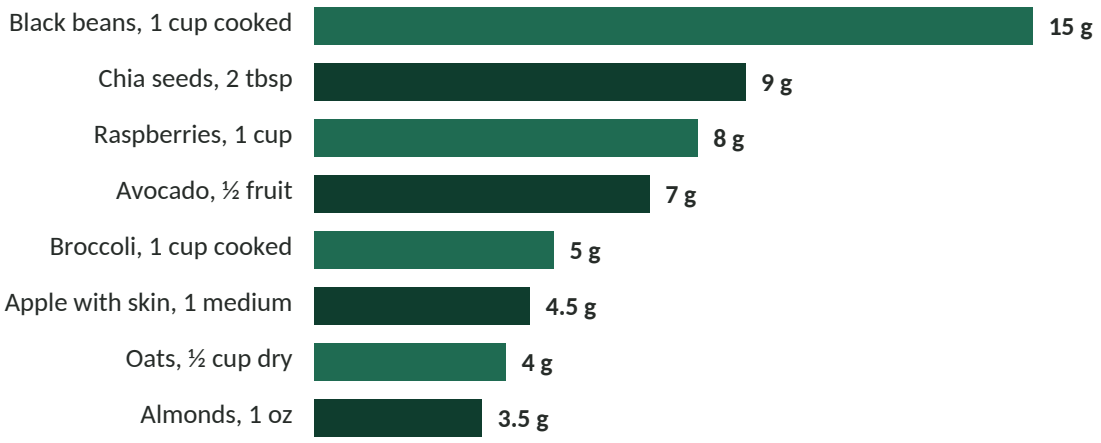
Meal	What's on the plate	kcal	Protein	Carbs
Breakfast	1 scoop protein powder in coffee or a smoothie, 1/2 cup Greek yogurt, 1/4 cup berries	200	36 g	12 g
Lunch	4 oz grilled chicken, large salad with 2 tsp olive oil, 1 cup quinoa	520	45 g	46 g
Dinner	4 oz salmon, 2 cups roasted vegetables, 1/2 sweet potato, 1 tsp olive oil	420	30 g	32 g
Snack	Protein shake with 1/2 banana, plus 1 string cheese	250	33 g	16 g
Total	about 44 g fat	**1,390**	**144 g**	**106 g**

This sample provides about 144 g protein, suited to a goal weight around 180 lb. Scale protein portions down for a smaller frame.

Fiber: the forgotten superpower

Fewer than 1 in 10 American adults meet the daily fiber recommendation, which is a missed opportunity. Fiber feeds beneficial gut bacteria, supports insulin sensitivity, increases fullness, helps lower cholesterol and keeps digestion regular.

> **HOW MUCH FIBER?**
>
> **Target:** about **25 g/day for women and 38 g/day for men**, or roughly 14 g per 1,000 calories you eat. (Your fiber target is separate from your protein target; they don't need to match.)



How to add fiber without digestive distress

Go slowly (about 5 g more per week) and drink more water as you go. Psyllium husk is a well-researched supplement if you still fall short.

Week	Step
1	Add one serving of vegetables to every meal
2	Swap refined grains for whole grains (oats for sugary cereal, brown rice for white)
3	Add one high-fiber snack daily (berries, nuts, seeds)
4	Consider a fiber supplement only if you're still under target

Seven easy swaps to try (one per day, then keep the ones you like)

Day	Swap	Adds
1	Stir chia seeds into breakfast	~9 g
2	White bread to whole-grain	3–5 g
3	Add ½ cup beans to lunch	~7 g
4	Raspberries instead of chips	~8 g
5	Add avocado to dinner	~7 g
6	Choose a high-fiber cereal (5 g or more per serving)	5–10 g
7	Count your day. Still short? Add one more swap.	—

2026 trends worth knowing

Hyper-personalised nutrition

At-home tests for genetics, microbiome and food sensitivities

Wearable glucose monitors for non-diabetics

AI meal planning from your data

Use data to inform, not dictate. Evidence for many consumer tests is still limited.

The microbiome focus

Gut health is linked with mood, immunity and weight

Fermented foods (kimchi, sauerkraut, kefir) support diversity

Prebiotic fiber feeds good bacteria

Action: include 1–2 fermented foods daily.

Sustainable eating

Plant-forward diets are good for health and the planet

You don't need to go vegan: aim for "more plants, better quality"

Cutting ultra-processed foods helps you and the environment

CHAPTER 6

6

Your Implementation Toolkit

Systems, schedules and safety nets that turn knowledge into a routine.

IN THIS CHAPTER

- The weekly planning system
- Batch-cooking guide
- Protein supplements decoded
- When things go off track
- Plateau-busting checklist

THE BIG IDEA

Plan once, cook once, eat many times. A simple weekly system removes daily decisions and makes the plan survive busy weeks.

The weekly planning system

Stop reinventing the wheel every Sunday. Use this four-step framework (about 30 minutes of planning, plus batch prep).

Step 1: Choose a theme (5 minutes)

Loose themes simplify decisions. Adapt them to your own week:

Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
Meatless (beans, lentils, tofu)	Taco or Thai night	Leftovers / clean out the fridge	High-protein focus	Date night or takeout	Batch-cook for the week	Meal-prep day

Step 2: Pick 3–4 core meals (15 minutes)

Don't plan 21 different meals. Choose two breakfasts, two lunches and three or four dinners, then repeat them. Variety is overrated when you're building consistency.

Meal	Example week
Breakfast	Oatmeal with protein (Mon / Wed / Fri); eggs and toast (Tue / Thu / Sat)
Lunch	Chicken grain bowl (Mon / Wed / Fri); large salad with protein (Tue / Thu)
Dinner	Salmon and rice (Mon); stir-fry (Tue); pasta (Wed); chicken tacos (Thu); pizza (Fri); steak (Sat); leftovers (Sun)

Step 3: Create your grocery list (10 minutes)

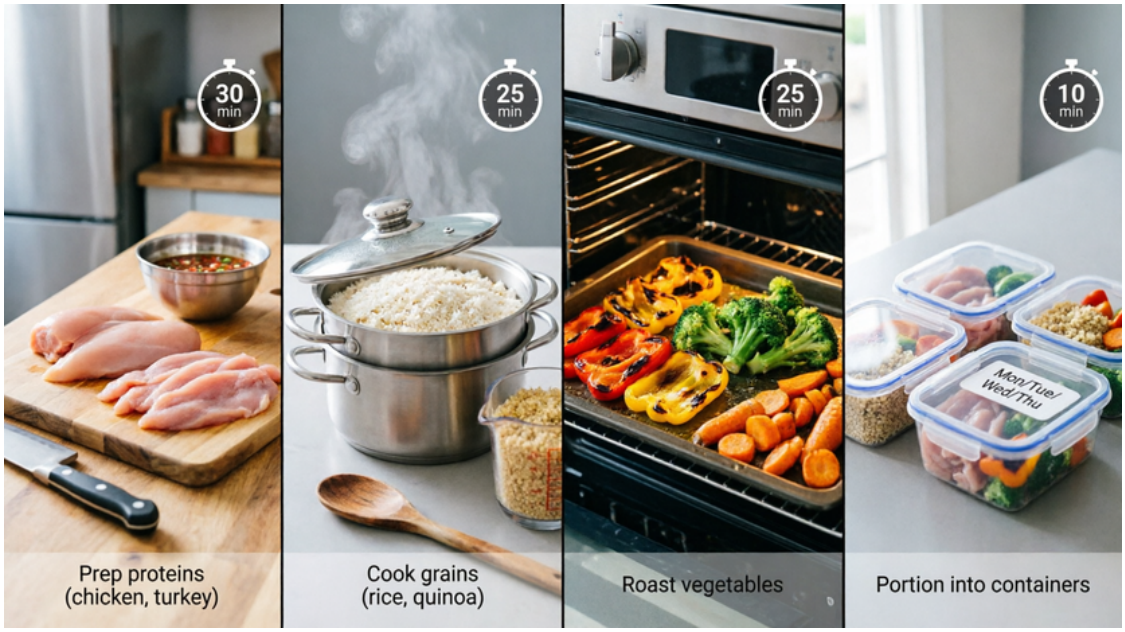
Organise by store section so you shop once, fast:

Produce	Protein	Carbs	Fats	Pantry
Leafy greens Broccoli, peppers, onions, carrots Berries, bananas, apples Fresh herbs	Chicken breast or thighs Ground turkey Eggs Greek yogurt Protein powder	Oats Rice (white or brown) Quinoa Whole-grain bread Potatoes, sweet potatoes	Olive oil Avocado Almonds, walnuts Chia and pumpkin seeds	Canned beans Canned tuna or salmon Spices Mustard, hot sauce, soy sauce

Step 4: Batch prep smart (60–90 minutes)

You don't need to prep every container. Cook **components** (proteins, carbs, vegetables) and mix and match all week: eggs and fruit for breakfast, chicken-rice-vegetables for lunch, turkey-quinoa-roasted vegetables for dinner.

Batch-cooking guide



Sunday prep schedule (90 minutes)

Time	Task
0:00–0:10 Set up	Preheat oven to 400°F (200°C). Start rice or quinoa on the stove. Wash all produce.
0:10–0:30 Proteins	Season chicken and roast 20–25 minutes (cook to 165°F / 74°C inside). Brown ground turkey. Hard-boil eggs (10–12 minutes).
0:30–0:50 Vegetables	Chop vegetables for roasting, toss with oil and seasoning, roast about 20 minutes. Wash and chop raw vegetables.
0:50–1:10 Carbs	Rice or quinoa should be done. Peel and cube sweet potatoes and roast or microwave.
1:10–1:30 Assembly	Portion proteins, divide carbs, store vegetables, make overnight oats for breakfast.

Storage guide

Food	Refrigerator	Freezer
Cooked proteins	3–4 days	Up to 3 months
Cooked grains (cool quickly)	3–4 days	Up to 3 months
Roasted vegetables	3–5 days	Up to 3 months
Raw chopped vegetables (airtight)	3–5 days	—

Food-safety tip: cool leftovers within two hours of cooking and reheat to 165°F (74°C). When in doubt, throw it out.

Protein supplements decoded

Food first, but powders are a convenient way to hit your protein target. Here's the breakdown:

Type	Protein	Best for	Pros	Cons	Price
Whey concentrate	70–80%	Budget-minded beginners	Affordable, tasty, effective	More lactose and fat	$
Whey isolate	90%+	Lactose-sensitive people	Higher protein %, low lactose	Costs more	$$
Hydrolyzed whey	90%+	Sensitive digestion	Pre-digested, quick to absorb	Premium price, can taste bitter	$$$
Casein	80–90%	Before bed	Slow-digesting, filling	Thick; may cause bloating	$$
Plant blend (pea/rice)	70–80%	Vegans, dairy-free	Dairy-free, hypoallergenic	Can be gritty; pick a blend for complete amino acids	$$
Clear protein	~90%	Preference	Mixes like juice	Pricey; no results advantage	$$$

KEY IDEA

Bottom line: whey concentrate is the budget default and works just as well for most people; choose isolate if lactose bothers you, and a pea/rice blend if you're vegan. Total daily protein matters far more than the type or exact timing.

Look for third-party testing (NSF Certified for Sport or Informed Choice) to avoid contaminated products.

If you...	Choose
are lactose intolerant	Whey isolate or plant-based
are on a budget	Whey concentrate
are vegan	Blended pea and rice protein
have a sensitive stomach	Hydrolyzed whey or plant-based
want something before bed	Casein (or Greek yogurt or cottage cheese)

When things go off track

You will miss a meal. You will eat the birthday cake. You'll have a weekend that derails your plan. **This is not failure. This is life.** What matters is the next move.

1. Don't compensate

Skipping the next meal or over-exercising creates a punishing cycle

One off-plan meal is maybe 500–1,000 extra calories

Gaining a pound of fat takes roughly 3,500 extra calories (a rule of thumb), so a spike on the scale is mostly water

2. Return to structure

One off-plan meal doesn't ruin progress

Three in a row starts a pattern

Next meal: back to your plan, no guilt

3. Ask what triggered it

Hunger? More protein and fiber earlier

Stress? Build non-food coping tools

Social pressure? Practise your response in advance

Boredom? Line up an alternative activity

4. Practise self-compassion

People who forgive themselves after a slip tend to recover faster than those who beat themselves up

Talk to yourself like you'd talk to a friend

THE "WHAT THE HELL" EFFECT

"I already ate a cookie, so what the hell, I'll eat the whole box and start Monday." That all-or-nothing spiral is the "what the hell" effect.

How to stop it: notice the thought; ask "Will this help or hurt my goals?"; remember progress beats perfection; then use the Two-Day Rule: just get back on track for today and tomorrow.

Plateau-busting checklist

A real plateau means your **weekly average weight** has been flat for 3 or more weeks despite consistent effort. Work down this list, changing one thing at a time:

- **Recalculate your TDEE.** Smaller bodies burn less: roughly 50–100 fewer calories per 10 lb lost. Adjust your target.
- **Audit your tracking.** Are you measuring oils and condiments, logging drinks and bites, and weighing instead of estimating? Track everything for 3 days.
- **Add 2,000 steps a day.** A 20-minute walk, stairs, parking farther away, standing while you work.

- **Take a diet break.** One to two weeks at maintenance can ease hunger and mental fatigue. Evidence is mixed, but many people find it helps them stick with the plan afterwards.
- **Prioritise sleep.** Aim for 7–9 hours. Short sleep shifts hunger hormones (more ghrelin, less leptin) and raises cravings.
- **Manage stress.** Chronic stress can raise appetite and disrupt sleep, and water retention can hide fat loss on the scale. Try meditation, breathing or yoga.
- **Change your training.** Add strength work if you only do cardio; raise volume or intensity; try something new.

WHEN TO SEEK HELP

No progress after 4+ weeks of doing all of the above

Symptoms of hormonal imbalance (irregular periods, extreme fatigue)

A history of disordered eating, or food and body image causing distress

Then consider a registered dietitian or certified coach.

APPENDIX A

A Sample Meal Plans

Pick the calorie level closest to your target, then swap foods freely.

INSIDE

- 1,500-calorie plan (3 days)
- 2,000-calorie plan (3 days)
- 2,500-calorie plan (3 days)
- Vegetarian and vegan alternatives

> **ABOUT THE NUMBERS**
> Calories and protein are estimates based on standard food values and can vary by 10% or more with brands and cooking methods. Weigh your food, check labels, and use these as templates, not prescriptions.

1,500-calorie plan

Day 1

Meal	What's on the plate	kcal	Protein	Carbs
Breakfast	Protein coffee smoothie: 1 scoop protein powder, 1 cup plain Greek yogurt, 1/2 cup berries	290	48 g	22 g
Lunch	4 oz chicken, large salad with 1 tbsp olive-oil dressing, 1 cup cooked quinoa	560	45 g	46 g
Snack	1 apple, 10 almonds	160	3 g	28 g
Dinner	5 oz salmon, 2 cups roasted vegetables, 2 tsp olive oil	460	35 g	18 g
Total	about 57 g fat	**1,470**	**131 g**	**114 g**

Day 2

Meal	What's on the plate	kcal	Protein	Carbs
Breakfast	2 eggs, 1 slice whole-grain toast, 1/2 avocado	340	18 g	21 g
Lunch	5 oz turkey in lettuce wraps with vegetables, 1/4 cup hummus, 1 apple	440	48 g	39 g
Snack	Protein shake (1 scoop) with 1 banana	220	26 g	29 g
Dinner	5 oz lean beef, 1 cup broccoli, 1 medium sweet potato, 1 tsp olive oil	480	48 g	38 g
Total	about 50 g fat	**1,480**	**140 g**	**127 g**

Day 3

Meal	What's on the plate	kcal	Protein	Carbs
Breakfast	Overnight oats: 1/2 cup oats, 1 scoop protein powder, 1 cup almond milk, 1/2 cup berries	340	30 g	41 g
Lunch	Tuna salad: 5 oz tuna, mixed greens, 1 tbsp olive oil, 1/4 cup chickpeas, 1 slice whole-grain toast	460	44 g	33 g
Snack	1 cup plain Greek yogurt, 1/2 cup berries	170	24 g	19 g
Dinner	5 oz chicken, 1.5 cups stir-fried vegetables, 1 cup brown rice, 1 tsp oil	560	52 g	58 g
Total	about 37 g fat	**1,530**	**150 g**	**151 g**

2,000-calorie plan

Day 1

Meal	What's on the plate	kcal	Protein	Carbs
Breakfast	1/2 cup dry oats cooked in water, 1 scoop protein powder, 1 banana, 1 tbsp honey	440	30 g	74 g
Lunch	6 oz chicken grain bowl: 1 cup rice, 1 cup vegetables, 1 tbsp sauce, 1 tsp olive oil	600	60 g	60 g
Snack	Protein shake, 1 apple, 1 tbsp peanut butter	310	30 g	30 g
Dinner	6 oz salmon, 1 cup quinoa, 2 cups vegetables, 1 tsp olive oil	700	49 g	57 g
Total	about 54 g fat	**2,050**	**169 g**	**221 g**

Day 2

Meal	What's on the plate	kcal	Protein	Carbs
Breakfast	3 eggs, 2 slices whole-grain toast, 1/2 avocado	500	28 g	35 g
Lunch	6 oz turkey sandwich (2 slices whole-grain bread, vegetables, mustard), side salad, 1 apple	570	62 g	64 g
Snack	1 cup Greek yogurt, 1/4 cup granola, 1/2 cup berries	300	26 g	39 g
Dinner	6 oz steak, 1 large sweet potato, 2 cups asparagus, 1 tsp olive oil	580	59 g	47 g
Total	about 59 g fat	**1,950**	**175 g**	**185 g**

Day 3

Meal	What's on the plate	kcal	Protein	Carbs
Breakfast	Smoothie: 1 scoop protein, 1 cup berries, 1 banana, 1 cup spinach, 1 tbsp almond butter	410	31 g	53 g
Lunch	6 oz chicken, 1.5 cups pasta with 1/2 cup marinara, side salad	690	67 g	79 g
Snack	Protein bar, 1 orange, 10 almonds	330	24 g	40 g
Dinner	6 oz white fish, 1 cup rice, 1.5 cups stir-fried vegetables, 1 tsp sesame oil	520	49 g	58 g
Total	about 43 g fat	**1,950**	**171 g**	**230 g**

2,500-calorie plan

Day 1

Meal	What's on the plate	kcal	Protein	Carbs
Breakfast	3/4 cup dry oats, 1.5 scoops protein powder, 1 banana, 1 tbsp peanut butter	600	49 g	76 g
Lunch	8 oz chicken, 1 cup rice, 1 cup vegetables, 1 tsp olive oil	670	77 g	54 g
Snack	Protein shake, 2 rice cakes, 1 tbsp almond butter, 1 apple	380	30 g	45 g
Dinner	7 oz salmon, 1 cup quinoa, 2 cups vegetables, 1/2 avocado	840	57 g	63 g
Total	about 78 g fat	**2,490**	**213 g**	**238 g**

Day 2

Meal	What's on the plate	kcal	Protein	Carbs
Breakfast	4 eggs, 2 slices whole-grain toast, 1 orange	510	34 g	45 g
Lunch	8 oz turkey grain bowl: 1.5 cups rice, vegetables, 2 tbsp sauce	750	77 g	88 g
Snack	2 cups Greek yogurt, 1/4 cup granola, 1 oz nuts	550	55 g	44 g
Dinner	8 oz lean beef, 1 large sweet potato, 2 cups vegetables, 1 tsp olive oil	730	74 g	55 g
Total	about 71 g fat	**2,540**	**240 g**	**232 g**

Day 3

Meal	What's on the plate	kcal	Protein	Carbs
Breakfast	Large smoothie: 2 scoops protein, 1 banana, 1 cup berries, 1 tbsp almond butter	520	54 g	55 g
Lunch	8 oz chicken, 1.5 cups pasta, 1/2 cup marinara, side salad with 1 tsp olive oil	820	85 g	79 g
Snack	Protein bar, 1 banana, 1 oz trail mix	440	25 g	62 g
Dinner	8 oz white fish, 1.5 cups rice, 2 cups stir-fried vegetables, 1 tsp oil	710	66 g	86 g
Total	about 56 g fat	**2,490**	**230 g**	**282 g**

Vegetarian and vegan alternatives

Protein swaps

Instead of...	Try...
Chicken	Tofu, tempeh, seitan, edamame
Beef	Lentils, black beans, textured vegetable protein
Fish	Chickpeas, white beans, hemp seeds
Eggs	Tofu scramble, chickpea flour
Greek yogurt	Soy or plant-based high-protein yogurt, silken tofu
Whey protein	Pea, rice or soy protein

Sample vegetarian day (about 1,950 kcal)

Meal	What's on the plate	kcal	Protein	Carbs
Breakfast	Tofu scramble: 1/2 block firm tofu with vegetables, 2 slices whole-grain toast	410	29 g	36 g
Lunch	Lentil bowl: 1 cup lentils, 3/4 cup quinoa, roasted vegetables, 1 tbsp tahini	550	30 g	86 g
Snack	1/4 cup hummus with raw vegetables, 1/2 whole-grain pita, 1/2 cup edamame	340	18 g	43 g
Dinner	Tempeh stir-fry: 6 oz tempeh, 1.5 cups vegetables, 1 cup brown rice, 1 tsp oil	650	39 g	75 g
Total	about 67 g fat	**1,950**	**116 g**	**240 g**

Vegans: check vitamin B12, iron, iodine, omega-3 (algae-based) and vitamin D with your clinician.

APPENDIX B

B

Quick Reference Guides

Pin these to the fridge: checklists, portions, emergency meals and hydration.

INSIDE

- Daily and weekly checklists
- Grocery staples
- Portion-size visual guide
- Emergency meal options
- Hydration and sleep

Daily and weekly checklists

Morning

- ☐ Weigh yourself (same time, same conditions)
- ☐ Take medications and supplements
- ☐ Eat within 1–2 hours of waking (if it suits you)
- ☐ Log yesterday's intake

All day

- ☐ Hit your protein target (0.7–1 g per lb)
- ☐ Drink water regularly
- ☐ Vegetables at 2+ meals
- ☐ Move for at least 30 minutes

Evening

- ☐ Finish dinner 2–3 hours before bed
- ☐ Rate energy, focus and satisfaction (1–10)
- ☐ Prep tomorrow's meals and snacks
- ☐ Aim for 7–9 hours of sleep

Weekly

- ☐ Plan meals for the week
- ☐ Grocery-shop with a list
- ☐ Batch-prep proteins, carbs, vegetables
- ☐ Review progress and adjust if needed

Grocery staples

Category	Staples
Proteins	Chicken breast/thighs; ground turkey (93% lean); eggs; Greek yogurt (plain, non-fat or 2%); protein powder; canned tuna/salmon; tofu/tempeh
Carbohydrates	Oats; rice (white, brown, jasmine); quinoa; whole-grain bread/wraps; potatoes/sweet potatoes; whole-grain pasta; whole-grain cereal
Fats	Extra-virgin olive oil; avocado; nuts (almonds, walnuts, cashews); seeds (chia, flax, pumpkin); natural nut butters; olives
Vegetables	Leafy greens; cruciferous (broccoli, cauliflower, Brussels sprouts); colourful (peppers, carrots, tomatoes, onions); frozen mixed vegetables
Fruit	Berries (fresh or frozen); apples; bananas; citrus; grapes
Pantry	Canned beans and tomatoes; broth; spices and herbs; condiments (mustard, hot sauce, soy sauce, salsa); vinegars

Portion-size visual guide

Food	Typical portion	Hand / object guide
Protein	3–4 oz cooked	Palm of your hand (women), two palms (men); deck of cards
Carbohydrates	½–1 cup cooked	Cupped hand; tennis ball to baseball
Fats	1 tbsp	Tip of your thumb; a pair of dice
Vegetables	1–2 cups	One to two fists; a baseball (1 cup)
Nuts and seeds	1 oz	Small handful; golf ball

Emergency meal options

No time

Protein shake + banana + tablespoon of peanut butter

Greek yogurt + berries + granola

Canned tuna + pre-washed greens + olive oil + lemon

Hard-boiled eggs + apple + cheese stick

Protein bar + fruit

Traveling

Gas station: jerky, nuts, bottled water

Airport: grilled chicken salad, dressing on the side

Hotel: grilled fish or chicken + vegetables

Road trip: cooler with pre-made meals and shakes

Too tired to cook

Rotisserie chicken + bagged salad + microwave rice

Frozen vegetables + canned beans + instant quinoa

Scrambled eggs + toast + fruit

Greek yogurt + granola + berries

Hydration

A simple starting point is about **half your body weight in pounds, in ounces of fluid per day** (a 150 lb person: roughly 75 oz, or about 9 cups), including water-rich foods and other drinks. Add more for long workouts, heat or higher fiber intake.

Signs you're well hydrated	Signs to drink more
Pale-yellow urine	Dark urine
Rarely thirsty	Persistent thirst, dry mouth
Steady energy	Headache, fatigue, dizziness

Needs vary with medical conditions and medication. Follow your clinician's advice if you have heart or kidney conditions.

Sleep optimisation checklist

1–2 hours before bed

- ☐ Dim the lights
- ☐ Limit screens or use a night mode
- ☐ Finish eating (no large meals)
- ☐ Caffeine cut-off about 8 hours before bed
- ☐ Limit alcohol (it fragments sleep)

Bedtime routine

- ☐ Same bedtime every night, even weekends
- ☐ Cool room (65–68°F / 18–20°C)
- ☐ Dark room (blackout curtains or eye mask)
- ☐ Quiet (white noise if needed)

If you can't sleep

- ☐ Get out of bed after about 20 minutes
- ☐ Do something relaxing (read, stretch)
- ☐ Return to bed when sleepy
- ☐ Don't watch the clock

APPENDIX C

C

FAQ: Your Questions Answered

Straight answers to the questions that come up most.

INSIDE

- Pace, alcohol and breakfast
- Hunger, muscle and protein
- Supplements, family and budget
- Plateaus and maintenance

How quickly should I expect to lose weight?

Aim for roughly 0.5–1% of body weight per week (0.5–2 lb for most people). Faster isn't better: it increases muscle loss and metabolic adaptation. If you're losing faster than that and feel terrible, eat more.

Can I drink alcohol and still lose weight?

Yes, in moderation. Alcohol has 7 calories per gram (almost as much as fat), and it can loosen food choices and disrupt sleep. Keep to 1–2 drinks, choose lower-calorie options (vodka soda, light beer), and count them in your daily intake.

Do I need to eat breakfast?

Not if you're not hungry. Meal timing is flexible. What matters is total daily intake and a pattern that helps you control hunger. Some people do better with intermittent fasting; others need breakfast to avoid overeating later.

How do I handle hunger?

First, make sure you're getting enough protein (0.7–1 g/lb) and fiber (25–35 g). Add vegetables for volume and drink water. If you're still hungry after two weeks, increase calories by 100–200 per day.

Can I build muscle and lose fat at the same time?

Yes, particularly if you're new to training, returning after a break, or have higher body fat. Prioritise protein (up to 1 g/lb), strength-train 3–4 times a week, and eat at a small deficit (200–300 calories) or at maintenance.

What if I don't like cooking?

Keep it simple: protein + vegetable + carb. Use shortcuts such as rotisserie chicken, pre-cut vegetables, high-protein frozen meals and meal-delivery services, or batch-cook once a week.

How do I know I'm eating enough protein?

Track for three days. If you're consistently around 0.7–1 g per pound of body weight, you're in range. Good signs: solid recovery from workouts, steady energy, satisfaction after meals. (If you have kidney disease, check your target with your doctor.)

Should I take supplements?

Food first. These are generally considered safe and useful for most healthy adults: protein powder (convenience), creatine monohydrate (3–5 g/day for strength), vitamin D (if deficient, get tested), omega-3 (if you don't eat fatty fish), and a multivitamin as insurance, not a replacement for food.

What if my family doesn't eat like this?

You don't need separate meals. Cook one meal and adjust portions. Family pasta night: you have 1 cup of pasta with extra chicken and vegetables; they have 2 cups of pasta. Same meal, different ratios.

How long will it take to see results?

Energy and sleep often improve within 1–2 weeks. Visible physical changes take about 4–8 weeks. Confidence and habit formation take 8–12 weeks or more. This is a marathon, not a sprint.

What if I hit a plateau?

See the Plateau-Busting Checklist in Chapter 6. Most plateaus come from inaccurate tracking, metabolic adaptation, water retention or a need for a diet break.

Can I do this on a budget?

Yes. Buy staples in bulk (rice, oats, frozen vegetables), choose cheaper proteins (eggs, canned tuna, chicken thighs, beans), cook at home, meal-prep to cut waste, and favour whole foods over packaged items.

How do I maintain after reaching my goal?

Raise calories gradually, by about 100–200 per week, until your weight stabilises. Keep tracking for 2–4 weeks to find your maintenance level, keep the habits you've built (protein, vegetables, movement), weigh weekly, and if you regain about 5 lb, return to a small deficit.

APPENDIX D

D

Resources and Next Steps

Tools, trusted sources and your 30-day plan.

INSIDE

- Recommended apps and equipment
- Further reading
- When to get professional help
- Your 30-day action plan

Recommended apps

Category	Apps
Tracking	Cronometer (accurate, micronutrients); MyFitnessPal (largest database); Lose It! (user-friendly); MacroFactor (adaptive targets)
Meal planning	Mealime (customisable plans); PlateJoy (personalised); Paprika (recipe organiser and grocery lists)
Fitness	Strong (strength log); Nike Training Club (free workouts); Strava (cardio and community)
Sleep and recovery	Sleep Cycle (tracking, smart alarm); Calm or Headspace (meditation and stress)

Kitchen equipment essentials

Must-have	Nice-to-have
Digital food scale ($15–20)	Instant Pot or slow cooker
Measuring cups and spoons	Air fryer
Sharp chef's knife and cutting board	Rice cooker
Non-stick skillet	Portioned meal-prep containers
2–3 sheet pans	Vacuum sealer (for batch cooking)
Food-storage containers	
Blender or food processor	

Further reading

Type	Suggestions
Books	*Atomic Habits* by James Clear (habit formation); *Burn* by Herman Pontzer (how energy expenditure really works); *The Hungry Brain* by Stephan Guyenet (appetite and food environment)
Websites	Examine.com (supplement and nutrition research); Precision Nutrition (evidence-based articles); Stronger By Science (research reviews); NIH Office of Dietary Supplements (fact sheets)
Mindset	Whatever you follow, be wary of anyone who sells certainty. Prefer sources that cite studies, show uncertainty and change their minds.

When to get professional help

Registered dietitian (RD/RDN)

You have a medical condition (diabetes, PCOS, thyroid issues)

You're pregnant or breastfeeding

You have a history of disordered eating

You want a personalised plan

Certified personal trainer

You're new to exercise

You have injuries or limitations

You want to build strength or muscle

You need accountability

Therapist or counsellor

You use food to cope with emotions

Anxiety or depression is affecting your eating

You struggle with body image

You want support with behaviour change

Your 30-day action plan

Week	Focus	Actions
Week 1	Observe	Read Chapters 1–2 · Download a tracking app · Start the 14-Day Discovery Protocol · Weigh daily and measure portions · Don't change anything yet
Week 2	Adjust	Read Chapters 3–4 · Work out your Week 1 average intake · Subtract 300–500 kcal for fat loss · Add **one** habit from Chapter 4 · Try one high-carb and one low-carb day (optional)
Week 3	Systemise	Read Chapters 5–6 · Build your first weekly meal plan · Do your first batch-cooking session · Start the energy-focus-satisfaction score · Add fiber-rich foods
Week 4	Refine	Review progress · Adjust using the metabolic-feedback rule · Add a second habit · Plan your next four weeks
Beyond	Live it	This becomes your lifestyle, not a "diet" · Reference the guides as needed · Adjust as goals change · Celebrate non-scale victories · Help others on their journey

Selected sources

Mifflin MD et al. (1990), *Am J Clin Nutr* · Levine JA et al. (1999), *Science* · Rosenbaum M, Leibel RL (2010), *Int J Obes* · Spiegel K et al. (2004), *Ann Intern Med* · Morton RW et al. (2018), *Br J Sports Med* · Byrne NM et al. (2018), MATADOR, *Int J Obes* · Hall KD et al. (2019), *Cell Metab* · Berry SE et al. (2020), PREDICT 1, *Nat Med* · US Dietary Guidelines for Americans, 2020–2025.



This Is Just the Beginning

You now have everything you need to build a sustainable, science-backed approach to nutrition. But knowledge without action is just entertainment.

YOUR NEXT STEPS

1. **Start the 14-Day Discovery Protocol** (Chapter 2) this week.
2. **Pick ONE habit** from Chapter 4. Master it before adding more.
3. **Schedule your first weekly planning session** (Chapter 6) in your calendar.
4. **Download a tracking app** and commit to 14 days of honest logging.

Remember: you're not building a 30-day body. You're building a lifetime of health, energy and confidence. Progress isn't linear. You'll have great weeks and messy weeks, and the difference between success and failure isn't perfection. It's persistence.

You've got this.

© 2026 The Master Meal Planning Guide by J.C. Storganau. For personal use only. This guide is for educational purposes and does not constitute medical advice. Consult a healthcare provider before making significant changes to your diet or exercise, especially if you have underlying health conditions or take medication.